The Seven Stage a Comeback

By Gregory Maguire

INTRODUCTION

(SING) Hi Ho! Hi Ho! It's off to work we go . . . . .
SNOW WHITE: *Reminds me of a dream I must have had. As if I had lived somewhere else, once upon a time. I never did, of course. I was always here, awake, and in my life. Smiling as if the happily ever after of stories begins right now, at the very start of life.*

For you see, Snow White went on to have her happily ever after. But what about her saviors: Dopey, Doc, Happy, Sleepy, Sneezy, Bashful and Grumpy? How did they feel when Snow White left them high and dry . . . after all they'd done for her. . . I think it's time for The Seven to Stage a Comeback by Gregory Maguire.

1: The man with the crazed expression
Clawed open her coffin,
Kissed her awake,
And carried her off.
There goes our lovely daughter.
All we have left of her
Is the apple that tumbled from her lips

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And the glass box we nested her in.

2: We're better off without her.
Wasn't she always on us about something?
"Hasn't anyone ever heard of a thing called soap?"
"I don't trust little men with beards."
And then with the signs.
The expressive eyes.
Followed by floods of agitated song.
Frankly, when she ate that poisoned apple –
Oh, yes, I was sad, I cried –
But you want to know what else?
I thought: *At last. A little peace and quiet around here.*

3: So why are your eyes all rimmed with red?
You loved her as we all did.
Or did you just like having someone to complain about?

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4: And all that's left is the apple and the coffin.
What could we do?
Put the bit of the apple in the glass coffin
And close it up again?
The coffin keeps things pretty fresh.
And for a good, long time, too, it seems.
You never know when we'll need a bit of poison apple again.

5: Let's take the coffin on our backs
And wander o'er the mountain tracks.
Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf.

6: This isn't the time for singing.
But it's not a bad idea.
Let's get this baby home.
All together now, on a count of three –
One, two – alley-oop and upsy-daisy.
You, carry the iron-head hammer.
And stop with that racket.

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7: Ohhhhhhh, ohhhhhhhh, ohhhhhhh, ohhhhhhhh, ohhhhhhhhh, ohhhhhhhhh

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1: We find an orphan girl, we take her in.
Locate some moldy blankets to keep her warm.
Porridge in the morning, porridge in the evening.
A little dwarf folk music to cheer her up.
It was a humble life, but it was ours,
And freely we gave it to her.
No wonder we're still upset.
No wonder we can't focus.
We have to shape up. We're falling to pieces here

2: Easy come, easy go.
We're better off without her.

3: You are the one who speaks with the sharpest tongue,

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But you're the one who moans her name in your sleep.
Face it. We all miss her.
When's the last time any one of us laughed out loud?
We don't manage to do what we should.
We never go out with our iron-head hammer
To bash the jewels out of secret caves.
But what can we do?

4: We could go find her where she is.
We could beg her to come back.
We could bring the glass coffin.
We could lay her where she was.

5: Let's take the coffin on our backs
Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf.

6: Please, would you stop your singing, please?
Though I'm not one for kidnapping old friends,
She did leave us high and dry.

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She married that traveling prince.
They could be nine kingdoms away by now.
But I'm a one for marching impressively off a cliff.
Better than sitting around with tears in our beards!
Let me hunt for a map, a compass.
We need cloaks, and staffs, and gumption.
Somebody grab the iron-head hammer,
Somebody bring the silver guitar.
You, are you weeping again, you fool?

7: Ohhhhh, ohhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhh

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1: Good-bye to the house in the autumn woods
There's no life left for us at home.
This little house, this moldy tomb – the grave and marker
Of what we lost when she went away.

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Now hoist the coffin on your backs,
And off we go.

2: We're better off without her.
We're better off without her.

3: So you say.
But you walk faster than the rest of us.
It never was to come to this
We took her in when she was lost,
But then we lost her in our turn.
And are we losing ourselves as well?

4: We'll find our beauty where she rests,
And coax her home.
What's wrong with that?
The least she owes us is a little loyalty.
She never should have eaten the apple, one,
Nor, two, attracted the first available prince.
Ours is not to harm or hurt her.
Just to keep her safely with us.

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5: We have the coffin on our backs
Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf.

6: You, are you weeping again, you fool?

7: Ohhh, ohhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhhh

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1: We'll cross this rushing icy mountain stream.
Don't drop the coffin into the flood,
For there it would sink, and clear as light,
We'd search in vain and never see it.
Steady your feet, and steady your hearts.

2: We're better off without her.
But should we come across her . . .
I'll be the one to ask her.
How she could ever leave use.
I'll laugh at any answer.

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We're better off without her.

3: We arent' her abductors.
Just friends who com a-calling.
We'll ask her to rejoin us.
The coffin waits.

4: The coffin waits.

5: Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf

6: I fear what we're about.
I cannot stop.
We are bewitched; no more, no less.
Her beauty calls us, and we can't escape.

7: Ohhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhh

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1: Here in the inn-yard, huddled about a fire,

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Today we learn that the girl we seek
Lives just beyond the ridge, in a noble home.
No dragons to guard the moat, no spells to break.
No soldiers lurking upon the singled roofs.
Nothing to stop us from going the final steps.
Here we'll commit what crime we may,
And live to rue, or praise the day.

7: Ohhhh, ohhhhh, ohhhhh

2: We're better off without her.
Let's give her the poisoned sleep
And lock her within her windows.
What's dead cannot live to leave us again.
We love her too much to allow her to live.

7: Oh, oh, oh, oh

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3: We're smaller than human men, with smaller hearts.
We aren't built to know what's right or wrong.
We're hardly more than pagan animals.
We met her when she was young, we took her in,
As much to serve us at our filthy home
As out of any wish to do charity.
Let's finish the job we started, and shed no tears
For being smaller creatures than we'd like.
Up to the mansion, then, to take her back.
There to cherish her incorruptible corpse.

7: Oh, oh, oh

4: The apple awaits to do it lethal job.
The glassy walls of the coffin are polished clear,
Its hinges oiled silent by dwarfish spit.

5: Let's lift the coffin from our backs
And see what sleeper it attracts.

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Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf.

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1: There she sits, in an orchard of apple trees.
Who could have thought she would be more beautiful
Than memory could picture?

2: We're better off without – we're better off – we're better

3: Hush, lest she hears us before we make our approach.
See how her smile blossoms; she looks aside,
Shyly, at mending collected inside the basket
That rests in the fragrant grass near her pretty feet.

4: She always loved the household task.
She sang when she worked.

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Who can forget her voice?

5: Sing ho, sing ho, sing ho,
Off with the girl and away we go.

6: She smiles upon the laundry with radiant look,
She stirs the cloth as if something lies gently within,
A bruisable apple, a blossom, a porcelain toy.
Now is the time. There is nobody else around.
At the count of three, we leap from these thickets, see,
Surround her – confound her – accuse her – reclaim her –
One – two –

7: Three
Is the number we never expected to see.
Yes, you will listen, all of you! Hear me out.
It is not just the prince and the princess we disturb.

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That basket of washing is laughing at its mother.
There is a child within. Are you wholly blind?
I'll swing this iron-head hammer at your skulls.
I'll smash the coffin seven directions to heaven.
Dwarfish mischief we make, and dwarfish music,
But mischief and music never come closer together
Than in the laugh of an infant adoring its mother.

3: We come to see what loneliness is worth;
It bring new life upon the ancient earth.

4: We smash the coffin of your former days
Seeing the happiness that spills in your gaze.

5: No coffin is left to life upon our backs
And carry home along the mountain tracks.
Sing ho! For the life of a dwarf.

6: No standing in splintered glass, in scented grass,
We sing you all our love, before we pass.

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7: All of us loved her as much as we could grieve.

As hard as we could do, each in our way.

Now hand me the silver guitar, and I will play

Hi Hooooooo, Hi Hooooooooo.

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